SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #92 · CHURCH & AUTHORITY

“Pastors and leaders are closer to God than I am.”

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Where it often comes from

Seeing leaders on a stage and feeling distant from them. Church cultures that treat clergy as a higher class of Christian. Feeling unqualified to pray or serve. Assuming that spiritual titles mean spiritual closeness. Your own sense of unworthiness.

What Scripture teaches

All believers are a royal priesthood, a people belonging to God. Every Christian can approach the throne of grace with confidence. Jesus told His disciples that they have one Teacher and one Father, and that they are all brothers and sisters. Righteousness comes through faith in Jesus to all who believe, with no distinction. Leaders have important roles, but they are not closer to God by position. Your access to God is as full as theirs.

> *“But you are a chosen people, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people for God’s own possession, to proclaim the virtues of Him who called you out of darkness into His marvelous light”* **(1 Peter 2:9)**.

Also see

> “Let us then approach the throne of grace with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace to help us in our time of need” **(Hebrews 4:16)**.

> “But you are not to be called ‘Rabbi,’ for you have one Teacher, and you are all brothers. And do not call anyone on earth your father, for you have one Father, who is in heaven. Nor are you to be called instructors, for you have one Instructor, the Christ” **(Matthew 23:8–10)**.

> “There is neither Jew nor Greek, slave nor free, male nor female, for you are all one in Christ Jesus” **(Galatians 3:28)**.

> “And this righteousness from God comes through faith in Jesus Christ to all who believe. There is no distinction, for all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God” **(Romans 3:22–23)**.

Common self-statements

- Pastors have a special connection to God that I don’t.
- God listens to leaders more than me.
- I’m just an ordinary church member.
- My prayers don’t count as much as theirs.
- I need a leader to hear from God for me.
- I’ll never be as close to God as they are.

Common logical errors

- **Comparison:** Measuring your closeness to God by someone else’s role.
- **Confusing role with relationship:** Assuming a title means greater access to God.
- **Discounting yourself:** Treating your relationship with God as second-class.
- **Labeling:** Calling yourself “just ordinary.”

Challenging questions

- What does 1 Peter 2:9 call all believers?
- Who can approach God's throne with confidence?
- What did Jesus say about titles in Matthew 23?
- Is there any distinction in how people are made right with God?
- Does a leader's role give them more access to God?
- What does my own relationship with God look like?
- How can I draw near to God today?

Truth summary

> Pastors and leaders are not closer to God than I am because of their role. I am part of a royal priesthood. Through Jesus, I can approach God's throne with confidence. Leaders serve important roles, but we are all brothers and sisters with one Father and one Teacher. My access to God is full and free.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Church
- Prayer, How to
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Chosen/Elect
- Humility

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Prayer
- Pride

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> **Overcoming Depression** · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Pastors and leaders are closer to God than I am"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Pastors and leaders are closer to God than I am." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What does God call all believers?
- ☐ Who can approach God's throne?
- ☐ What did Jesus say about titles?
- ☐ Is there distinction in how we're saved?
- ☐ Does a role give more access to God?
- ☐ How can I draw near to God today?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I am part of a royal priesthood.
- ☐ I can approach God's throne with confidence.
- ☐ We all have one Father and one Teacher.
- ☐ There is no distinction in Christ.
- ☐ My access to God is full and free.
- ☐ Leaders serve; they do not stand between me and God.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **1 Peter 2:9**
  "But you are a chosen people, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people for God's own possession, to proclaim the virtues of Him who called you out of darkness into His marvelous light."
- [ ] **Hebrews 4:16**
  "Let us then approach the throne of grace with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace to help us in our time of need."
- [ ] **Matthew 23:8–10**
  "But you are not to be called 'Rabbi,' for you have one Teacher, and you are all brothers. And do not call anyone on earth your father, for you have one Father, who is in heaven. Nor are you to be called instructors, for you have one Instructor, the Christ."
- [ ] **Galatians 3:28**
  "There is neither Jew nor Greek, slave nor free, male nor female, for you are all one in Christ Jesus."
- [ ] **Romans 3:22–23**
  "And this righteousness from God comes through faith in Jesus Christ to all who believe. There is no distinction, for all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God."

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Nearness log:** Each day, write one way I drew near to God myself.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, 1 Peter 2:9 becomes: "But **Sarah** is chosen, a royal priest, holy, belonging to God, to proclaim the virtues of Him who called **her** out of darkness into His marvelous light."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Chosen/Elect" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Spend ten minutes each day this week** talking to God yourself, without waiting for a leader.
- ☐ **Read Hebrews 4:14–16 and 10:19–22,** and write what they say about your access to God.
- ☐ **Share something God has shown you** with another believer.
- ☐ **Thank a leader for their service,** remembering they are a brother or sister in Christ.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Pastors and leaders are closer to God than I am": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One way I drew near to God
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Pastors and leaders are closer to God than I am.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, thank You that through Jesus I can come to You myself. Help me reject the lie that pastors and leaders are closer to You than I am. Thank You for making me part of a royal priesthood. Draw me near to You today. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.